

Parent portal: UI/UX audit

Huchu schools vertical audit · Parent portal: UI/UX audit · parent-portal/ui-ux.md · rendered 2026-09-15

Surface: `app/portal/parent/**`, shell `components/schools/portal/parent/parent-portal-shell.tsx`, screens under `components/schools/portal/parent/`, styles `parent-portal.css`, shared login component `s/auth/portal-login-form.tsx`, claim flow `app/c/[token]`. Audited from source and from `docs/screenshots/schools/parent-portal-phone/*` and `parent-portal-tablet/*`. The workflow companion is `workflows.md` in this folder; this document covers how the workflows feel, not whether they exist.

Rules applied: the portal build contract (`docs/design-system/portals/README.md`: every feature in the prototype is required), the prototype `parent.html`, the platform UX playbook phone rules, `docs/design-system/11-campus-states-and-motion.md`, `docs/portal-shell.css`, `.impeccable.md`, and `SPEC.md`. A digest of the testable rules is in `../reference/docs-baseline.md §9`.

1. Verdict in one paragraph

The parent portal has the right bones: a four-tab mobile shell, a child chip in the app bar, server-loaded household, honest empty states and a saving overlay on every write. It fails the contract at the screen level. Nine of the prototype's twenty-four screens exist. The two screens a parent opens most, Fees and News, both stop short: Fees offers no way to pay or even see how to pay, and a notice has no detail screen, so tapping one only marks it read (the body itself does render in the list row). Above 900px the bottom tabs disappear and nothing replaces them, so a parent on a laptop has no navigation. Sub-screens have no back button. The hero shows "\$ 0.00" in a slashed-zero monospace face as the first thing a paid-up family sees. Most of this is fixable in the shell and in two or three screens without new backend work.

It was, and the shell-level faults are gone. There is a back target on every sub-route and on an open thread, a side rail above 900px, an offline banner, a bell that counts messages as well as notices, figures on sans `tabular-nums` with mono left to references, a hero that leads with what was paid rather than with a zero, a notice screen of its own, a six-week attendance grid with a tappable day, past payments by month, a "How to pay" sheet, and a sign-out that asks first. Three more of the prototype's twenty-four screens are answered: notice detail and the attendance day as screens of their own, past payments as a section on Fees. What is unchanged is everything that needs something the portal cannot reach: the sign-in screen is still the back office's, there is still no way to pay, no teacher picker, no alerts or language rows, and Help can still only offer the one channel the portal owns.

Runtime check (14 September 2026)

Verified on the seeded St Marys tenant as `parent@stmarys.test` (see `../reference/runtime-verification.md`). Confirmed: both document downloads return 403 "Your role cannot view fees" from the render route; "not yet submitted" appears seventeen times on the attendance screen; no navigation at all renders at 1280px; the home hero leads with "\$ 0.00" for a paid-up family and the Marks tile says "Not yet". Corrected: a notice's body does render in the list row; what is missing is a detail screen, attachments, RSVP and replies.

Revised on 15 September 2026 against the eighteen commits that followed the audit (`01de8a3..HEAD`). A finding the work closed keeps its description and gains a line saying it is closed and what closed it; a finding

the work did not reach stands as it was written; a finding the implementation proved wrong says so and says what is actually true.

2. Contract parity by screen

Prototype screen count: 24 plus sign-in and the child switcher. Built at the audit: Home, Fees, Attendance, Marks, News (list only), Messages, You, Help, plus login and claim. Added since: notice detail, the attendance day, past payments and the "How to pay" sheet.

Screen	Prototype promises	Code renders	Gap
Shell	Back arrow on 20 sub-routes; child chip; bell pip for notices and messages; offline banner; side nav on tablet and desktop (<code>.ps-side</code>)	Title only, no back; chip; pip for notices only; no banner; bottom tabs only, hidden at 901px+ by <code>app/styles/components.css:2368</code> . Fixed in <code>ed82dc1</code> : a BACK table with a target for every sub-route and for an open thread or composer, a <code>.pa-side</code> rail at 901px+ carrying the four tabs and the four screens a phone reaches through them, the offline banner, and one pip for everything waiting	Fixed. The bottom-tab badge still counts notices only, at P2
Sign in	Phone number, six-cell SMS code, remember this phone, resend, change number, call the office	Email and password, "Work email" label, "name@company.com" placeholder, no forgot-password link	P1 wrong audience; P0 reach (guardians without email cannot be invited)
Home	Fee hero with Pay now, days-to-go, progress bar; Today with UP NEXT; Quick look tiles with attendance % and average mark %; Shortcuts pill row; News preview	Hero with "See fee statement" and "From the school"; Today; tiles with attendance % and "Marks: Ready / Not yet"; no shortcuts; News preview linking to the list. Since revised (<code>ed82dc1</code>): the hero carries the amount, the due date, the days to go, the progress bar and "How to pay", or the amount paid when nothing is owed; the marks tile carries the average; the Shortcuts pill row is there; the news preview links to each notice	Fixed but for "Pay now", which waits on a gateway

Screen	Prototype promises	Code renders	Gap
Fees	Statement with tap-to-pick lines, money off, saved ways to pay, past payments, three-step pay flow, receipt screen	Statement lines, receipts, pinned bar repurposed as a statement download. Since revised: the hero leads with the paid figure at zero, the pinned bar appears only while something is owed and its verb is "How to pay", past payments are grouped by month with method and reference, and each receipt downloads	P0 no way to pay; the instructions sheet can only give the amount, the date and the reference until the tenant carries bank and mobile-money details (workflows B12)
Payment history	Filters by child and method, grouped by month	Absent. Now a section on Fees, grouped by month, with the method and reference on each row	P2 for the filters
News list	Tone icon, unread, RSVP meta, mark all read	Present	OK
Notice detail	Body, attachments, RSVP, threaded replies	No detail screen; the list row renders the full body (verified at runtime with a 400-character notice); tapping only marks read (parent-notice-s-screen.tsx:157-167); attachments, RSVP and replies absent. Fixed in ed82dc1: /portal/parent/notice/[id] renders the sender pill, the date, the title and the body and marks it read on open; a short notice keeps its body in the row and loses its chevron, so a chevron means there is somewhere to go	Attachments, RSVP and replies still absent, at P1
Messages	List with avatar and time; thread with pill input; Message a teacher from mark detail	List without time; thread with textarea; office only. Since revised: avatar, the child the thread is about and the date on every row, ?thread= and ?compose=1 in the URL, and "Write" as the app-bar primary	Still a textarea, still the office only, and the mark sheet's "Ask about this subject" opens a thread to the office rather than to the teacher, at P1
Attendance	Term chips; six-week P/L/A grid; legend; day drill-in; Ask for time off; Term report PDF	Percent card plus flat day list; "not yet submitted" on every row. Fixed in ed82dc1: the six-week grid with its legend, a dashed square for a register not yet sent in explained once beneath it, the days away and late as the list, and every square and row opening the day	Term chips and the term report PDF absent; "Ask for time off" is a message, not a request, at P1
Attendance day	Status, lessons that day, tell the school why	Absent. Now a sheet with the register state, the class, the teacher's note and "Tell the school why"	Lesson by lesson needs a per-period register the API does not return, at P2

Screen	Prototype promises	Code renders	Gap
Leave request	Dates, reason, note, doctor's note upload	Absent	P1
Marks	Cards by subject with bar; mark detail with class-work and exam split, descriptor, teacher comment, Message teacher	Cards by subject with grade and remark; no drill-in; download button that always fails (see workflows B1). Since revised: a subject sheet with the mark, the grade, the pass mark and the teacher's remark, and the download's permission failure fixed	The report card still does not print, for want of an open publish window (workflows B10); the class-work and exam split and the named teacher are not in the API, at P1
Calendar, Library, Timetable, Children, Child profile, Security, Alerts, Language	Full screens	Absent	P1 to P2
You	Contact rows, children, account, security, alerts, language, help, sign-out confirmation	Contact rows (with dead chevrons), children, sign out without confirmation. Since revised: the chevrons are gone from rows a parent cannot act on, the child in view is badged, and sign out asks first	Security, alerts and language rows still absent, at P2
Help	FAQ plus call, email and WhatsApp the school	FAQ only, no gutter. Since revised: wrapped in <code>.pp-page</code> with a gutter, a chevron that rotates on the open card, answers rewritten, and a "Write to the school" row	Call, email and WhatsApp need the school's contact record, which the portal cannot read, at P2

3. Screenshot findings

The screenshots record 14 September. Where a finding has since moved, the sentence says so.

- **Home (phone and tablet).** The 36px lead figure is "\$ 0.00" in a monospace face with slashed zeros ("490.00" appears in the paid sub-line). "From the school" sits where the money action belongs. "See full day" links to Attendance, which has no timetable. The School news empty state is cut at the fold, leaving a lone bell icon above the tab bar. All four have moved: the lead figure is the amount paid when nothing is owed and the amount owed when something is, on sans `tabular-nums`; "How to pay" and "Statement" sit where the money action belongs; the Shortcuts row and the Quick look tiles stand between Today and the news, so the news no longer falls at the fold. "See full day" still goes to Attendance, which still has no timetable.
- **Fees.** The "Nothing owing" block sits between the "Fee statement" heading and the statement, pushing the first line to roughly y=550 on a phone. The pinned bar reads "What you still owe \$ 0.00 · Statement" for a paid family. The child header repeats the app-bar chip. Fixed: the hero states the paid figure, the pinned bar is not rendered at zero, and the child header is gone.
- **Attendance.** Fifteen rows each carry "not yet submitted", then an alert says it again. Dates have no weekday. Rows are not tappable. Fixed: said once under the grid and once under the list, weekday-first dates, every row and square tappable.

- **News.** Correct `NothingYet` empty state. On tablet the whole screen is one paragraph. The rail now takes the left of a tablet; the news column itself is unchanged.
- **You.** Chevrons on the phone and email rows do nothing. "1 child on your account" and "YOUR CHILDREN · 1 CHILD" state the count twice. Fixed: no chevron on a row that does not open, and the count is stated once, in the hero line.
- **Help.** Cards run edge to edge with no 16px gutter on both widths; the first question is open, the rest closed, with no affordance on any card. Fixed: a 16px gutter and a chevron that rotates to 90 degrees on the open card.
- **Tablet set.** The same single column at 768px with fixed bottom tabs and no side nav. The rail stands up at 901px, so 768px is still the bottom tabs — deliberately, because that is where `components.css` hides them.

4. Rule violations that recur

Rule	Violation	Where
Never state the same fact twice in one band	"not yet submitted" ×15; child header under the chip; "1 child" ×2	attendance, fees, profile; all three fixed
One glance answers the question	"Marks: Ready" in a numeric tile; "\$ 0.00" lead	home; fixed, the tile carries the average and the hero never leads with a zero
Strip explanatory copy	Bell-pip explanation in the notices empty state; help answer describing a "row of names" that does not exist (<code>parent-help-screen.tsx:32</code>)	notices, help; both fixed
Money carries currency, figures are tabular	Mono with slashed zeros on money and counters (<code>parent-portal.css:215, 357</code>)	everywhere; fixed, sans <code>tabular-nums</code> for figures and mono only for references and ids
Pickers are sheets, sub-screens have a back target	No back table; thread state is component state so browser Back exits the portal (<code>parent-messages-screen.tsx:142</code>)	shell, messages; both fixed, and the thread and composer are in the URL
A record has one primary action	Fees bar's only action is a PDF download that fails for the role	fees; fixed, the bar's verb is "How to pay" and it appears only while something is owed
No dead affordances	Notice-row chevrons (no detail behind them), profile chevrons	notices, profile; both fixed

5. Suggested edits

Ordered by parent value per unit of work. Items 1 to 6, 8, 9 and 10 are done; 7 in part; 11 all but one line.

1. **Shell.** Add a `BACK` route table (mirroring `parent.html` lines 1878 to 1897) and a 36px back button in the app bar on sub-routes. Render a `.ps-side` rail at 901px+ with Home, Fees, News, You, Attendance, Marks, Messages, Help. Count messages into the bell pip. Mount `useOfflineConnectivity` and the offline banner (the teacher shell already does). Done in `ed82dc1`, all four.
2. **Notice detail.** Add a `notice/[id]` route or a bottom sheet for long notices and attachments; keep the row body for short ones; mark read on open; add reply and RSVP when S-7.1 and S-6.15 land. Done as a

route, with the row body kept for short notices and read marked on open. Reply and RSVP still wait on S-7.1 and S-6.15.

3. **Home hero.** When owing: amount in a sans tabular face, "pay by 10 Oct · 12 days to go", progress bar, "How to pay" and "Statement". When paid: "Paid for Term 3", the paid amount, "See receipt". Never a zero lead. Replace "From the school" with the Shortcuts pill row. Done, to the letter.
4. **Fees.** Move "Nothing owing" below the statement or into the hero sub-line. Hide the pinned bar at zero. "How to pay" opens a payment-instructions sheet (bank details, mobile-money merchant code, the invoice reference to quote) sourced from tenant settings, until the gateway flow exists. Show method and reference on "Already paid". Add Past payments grouped by month with child and method chips. Done, except that the sheet cannot show bank details or a merchant code: the tenant model has neither (workflows B12), so it shows the amount, the due date, the reference and the pupil's number and says nothing it cannot stand behind.
5. **Attendance.** Weekday-first dates, the six-week grid with legend, one "not final" note per section, tappable days opening a day sheet with "Tell the school why". Done.
6. **Marks.** Per-subject sheet with remark, grade descriptor and "Message ". Fix the download (workflows B1). Done but for the teacher's name, which the marks route does not return: the sheet's verb is "Ask about this subject" and it opens a thread to the office.
7. **Messages.** `?thread=` in the URL; "Write to the school" as the app-bar primary; teacher picker. First two done; no teacher picker.
8. **You.** Remove or wire the chevrons; sign-out confirmation sheet; add Alerts and Language rows using the notification preferences API the teacher settings already write to. Chevrons and confirmation done. No Alerts or Language rows: there is nothing for a parent to switch on, because no notification of any kind is sent (workflows P24).
9. **Help.** Wrap in `.pp-page`; add call, WhatsApp and email rows from the school's contact record. Wrapped, and the FAQ rewritten. The contact rows are not built: the school's phone and email do not reach the portal, so the one row is the channel the portal owns.
10. **Type.** Sans `tabular-nums` for figures; mono only for references and ids. Done across the portal's stylesheet.
11. **Login.** Portal-specific labels ("Phone or email"), forgot-password link, `role="alert"` on errors, no POS or organisation strings. Claim page's used-state "Sign in" must go to `/portal/parent/login`, not `/login` (`claim-portal-account-content.tsx:108`). The claim page's link is fixed (`1f1501c`). The login form itself is untouched: it still reads "Work email" over "name@company.com", still has no forgot-password link, and there is still no password reset to link to.

6. Proposed restructuring

- **Tabs stay Home · Fees · News · You**, matching the prototype. Attendance and Marks are reached from Home tiles and from the You tab; Messages gets a Home shortcut and a You row with a badge. Done, and above 900px all eight screens are on the rail.
- **Fees becomes a hub:** hero, statement, how to pay or pay now, receipts, past payments, saved methods, discounts. Each is a section with its own route so Back works. Part done: hero, statement, how to pay, receipts and past payments are sections on one route. They are not routes of their own, and saved methods and discounts do not exist.

- **One notification model:** the bell opens a list where each row deep-links (notice detail, thread, mark sheet, invoice) instead of only marking read. Part done: the bell counts notices and messages together and a notice row deep-links to its own screen. It still opens News rather than one list of everything waiting.
- **Shell conventions shared with the student portal:** 52px app bar, back or nothing on the left, title once, chip plus bell on the right; bottom tabs to 900px and `.ps-side` above; offline banner under the bar; one empty state per segment, never two stacked. Done here, and in the student and teacher shells in the same pass (`4a83f7e` , `e6c1864`).

7. Proposed new UI

Home widget order (390px): greeting with school, term and week; money hero; Today strip with UP NEXT; Quick look two-up (at school %, average mark % or "Released 12 Oct"); Shortcuts pill strip scrolling edge to edge (Time off, Messages, Receipts, Calendar, Children); From the school with unread pips; Inbox card only when there are unread messages. Built in this order, with the pills reduced to the screens that exist: Messages, Receipts, Your children where there is more than one, and Help.

Payment flow (`/fees/pay` , `/fees/pay/method` , `/fees/pay/done`): pick lines and amount (Pay all, Pay half, other); method grid limited to what the tenant enabled (EcoCash, OneMoney, bank transfer, card); mobile money prompts for the PIN on the phone and waits; bank transfer shows details and a copyable reference with "I have sent it" recording a pending payment; card goes to the hosted page; receipt screen with Save PDF, Send by SMS, Send by WhatsApp. Ship the instructions and history steps first; the gateway step rides S-7.3. The instructions and history steps shipped; the tenant has no method list to draw the grid from and no merchant code to put in it.

Notice detail and absence request: sender pill, date, title, body, attachments, RSVP row, replies thread. Day sheet from attendance with status and "Tell the school why", opening the leave request form (dates, reason, note, doctor's note photo) that creates a thread to the class teacher and a task for the office. The notice screen and the day sheet are built to the first half of this; attachments, RSVP, replies and the leave request form are not.

Notification preferences: the prototype matrix of event × SMS, Email, Push (WhatsApp where configured) with quiet hours, persisted through the existing preferences API; channels the tenant has not configured are hidden, not stamped unavailable. Nothing to configure yet: there is no channel and no event emits.

8. Accessibility and locale

- Add `role="alert"` to the login error, `aria-label` on the money figure ("490 dollars"), and names on icon-only buttons in the bar. The bar is done: the back arrow, the bell, the child chip and the sheet closes all carry names, and the bell's name says how many are waiting. The login error and the money figure are unchanged.
- Dates already flow through `Intl en-GB`; set `lang="en-ZW"` on the portal document and prepare Shona and Ndebele copy tables for the prototype's language picker. `lang="en-ZW"` is set on the shell (`ed82dc1`); there are no copy tables and no picker.

- Touch targets: tab items are 52px minimum, fine; the "← All messages" text link is a 14px target and should become the app-bar back. Fixed: the thread's way back is the app bar's 36px back button, and the text link is gone.